



Right choice: Accountability has been one of the biggest virtues of the 48-year-old, media-shy coach. PICS: AIFF MEDIA

the third since 1993. One Indian has taken interim charge since — Armando Colaco — after the sacking of Bob Houghton.

“Indian coaches know the (team) atmosphere and everything about the players. That is an advantage, and their learning capacity is also very good. If they get a chance, they can do well,” Jamil says.

Having played under some of the best gaffers in modern Indian football, from Dhyan Chand Awardee Sukhwinder Singh to Arjuna Awardee and former India captain Syed Nayeemuddin, Jamil has grown into a repository of accumulated wisdom.

“I have worked with many coaches, both foreign and Indian. All of them have been good and I have learnt many things from them,” he adds.

An uphill battle

Jamil’s first assignment will be a stern challenge — against Tajikistan (2023 Asian Cup quarterfinalist), Iran (a three-time Asian Cup winner) and Afghanistan (a side India has not beaten in over three years), at the 2025 CAFA Nations Cup.

“It is good for us to play against stronger teams. Everybody is motivated to participate,” Jamil says. “There is no complaint at all. We must work hard. Looking at the opponents, yes, they are good teams, but we have to be prepared for that.”

India’s preliminary squad has been training under Jamil in Bengaluru since August 15, and will fly to Tajikistan for its group-stage matches.

The squad already has some surprise selections, with record goalscorer and captain Sunil Chhetri excluded and likely out of Jamil’s plans for the impending Asian Cup qualifiers.

“Sunil (Chhetri) is a role model for Indian football, and the door is always open for him. He’s not in the camp because we are playing a tournament that will essentially serve as preparation for our Asian Cup qualifiers, and I want to try out a few other players,” Jamil had earlier clarified.

Moreover, Mohun Bagan Super Giant, the defending ISL champion, has declined to release its players as the tournament is outside the FIFA window and clashes with its AFC Champions League Two commitments in September.

On the other hand, the camp has welcomed four new personnel: defenders Sunil Benchamin (the first from the Indian Army Football Team in four decades), Alex Saji, Muhammed Uvais, and forward Manvir Singh.